

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH  
*of Los Angeles*

*Fall Series 6*

*Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul*

*Reawakening to What Our Souls Already Know*

*11 October 2026*



*Hot Springs: Yavapai Co. Arizona, Maxfield Parrish, 1902*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020  
Telephone 213.385.1341 – [www.FCCLA.org](http://www.FCCLA.org)

## **The Gathering of the People**

*First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...*

*We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time.*

*Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~*

*Please note that our services are live streamed at [fccla.org/live](http://fccla.org/live).*

### **Organ Prelude Concert**

TBD

**Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence**

### **Chiming of the Hour**

#### **Welcome**

**Rev. Laura Vail Fregin**

#### **Words of Gathering**

**Rev. Fregin, Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio**

*Fountain of life...*

*Pulse of life...*

*Breath of life...*

*Earth is filled with the presentness of God.*

*A planet filled with the presence of God  
a living green blue planet,  
people from every corner of creation,  
the vast reaches of space above us,  
and the rocks and hills and wonders of the wild.*

*Together this day,  
let us sense and feel  
the face of God in all creation.*

*Together this day,  
let us celebrate the life-giving  
breath of our God.*

*Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

#### **\*Hymn of Gathering**

**Creator God You Gave Us Life**

OLD HUNDRETH

*Creator God, you gave us life,  
Your image formed within our souls,  
Yet through the mist of time and space,  
We search for that which makes us whole.*

*Through hands that paint majestic skies,  
And voices chanting melody,  
With words that reach beyond the page,  
We comprehend your mystery.*

In every flow'r and every tree,  
We see your great diversity,  
Yet greater still we see your love,  
Expressed in our humanity.

When with our hearts, our hands our minds,  
We share our gifts with all the world,  
Our spirits soar beyond the veil,  
To touch the very face of God.

**\*Prayer of Awareness**

**Rev. Fregin**

God of love, show us our place in this world  
as channels of your love  
for all the creatures of this earth -  
for not one of us is forgotten in your sight.

Enlighten those who possess power and money  
that they may avoid indifference,  
that they may love the common good,  
advance the weak,  
and care for this world  
in which we live.  
The poor, the oppressed, and the earth  
are crying out.

So we ask, Good and Gracious God, seize us with your power,  
with your beautiful darkness, with your amazing light,  
and help us to protect all life,  
with all that we have and all that we are  
as we work for your kin-dom  
of justice, peace, love, and beauty.

-adapted from the Pope's Encyclical, 2015

***Amen and Amen.***

**\*Introit**

**Iona Alleluia** TRADITIONAL CELTIC FROM THE ISLAND OF IONA

Frank Hobbs, *Soloist*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

**\*The Lord's Prayer**

**Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio**

*Our [God], who art in heaven,  
hallowed be thy Name,  
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,  
on earth as it is in heaven.  
Give us this day our daily bread,  
and forgive us our debts,  
as we forgive our debtors.  
And lead us not into temptation,  
but deliver us from evil.  
For thine is the kingdom,  
and the power, and the glory,  
forever.*

*Amen.*

**\*Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,  
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.  
World without end, Amen, Amen.

**\*Passing of the Peace**

**Rev. Fregin**

For the gift of this new day  
for waking again from the dreams of the night  
for our bodies strengthened and our minds renewed  
*Thanks be to you, O God.*

You are the stillness of the night,  
you are the genesis of the morning  
you are the dew of new creation.

*Let there be peace in the human soul  
let there be waking to new consciousness*

In the life of the world this day  
and in our hearts  
let there be fresh hope for peace.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.  
*And also with you!*

*You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow*

*Please be seated*

**Reading from Our Religious Tradition**  
*From the Gospel of John*

**Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio**

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.  
*Thanks be to God!*

**Prayers with the People**

**Rev. Fregin**

**Invitation to Silence and Prayer**

*Silence*

**Prayer of Our Hearts**

Creator Spirit,  
we give thanks that your life-giving Presence  
has been active in our universe for all the billions of years  
that have passed since the first moments of its existence.

Working within and with what was there,  
your Presence came to visible expression  
in the formation of stars  
and galaxies  
and planets.

Rocks and grasses,  
water and soil,  
all living things, including us,  
came to life with a conscious  
awareness and appreciation  
of your Presence.

Help us on this day  
to marvel at this life,  
as we continue to embrace  
this Sacred Earth we call home.

*Help us on this day  
to celebrate the Source of all that is  
and of all that shall be. Amen.*

[mmorwood / adapt]

### **Meditation Anthem**

TRADITIONAL AFRICAN-AMERICAN SPIRITUAL arr. MOSES HOGAN

#### **This Little Light of Mine**

Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloist*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

### **Sermon**

*Reawakening to What Our Souls Already Know*

**Rev. Michael Lehman**

### **The Eucharist and Blessings**

**Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman**

### **Words of Invitation and Remembrance**

We are drawn together by the Wisdom of the universe,  
nature's intelligence,  
embodied in Jesus  
and present in all souls  
who gather at Wisdom's table.

*We gather to receive grace to give up our foolish ways,  
to walk in Wisdom's light,  
to delight in creation and in one another,  
as the Holy One delights in us.*

May we open the gates of our souls, that Wisdom may enter,  
making us friends of God and one another.

*We open in this time to the  
transforming power of the Spirit.*

### **Sharing of the Bread and the Cup**

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

### **Invitation to Generosity**

**Emily Kang**

Each morning brings us a newness  
that we but need to step into.  
It can wash us,  
lift us,  
heal us,  
hold us  
just as each of us has need.

As we give from our financial resources this morning,  
to continue the work of this church  
may we be open to the power that lies within us.  
May we be full with a confidence in our strength.  
May we move from empty routines  
to the fullness of life  
that we might live God's dream.

*At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at [fccla.org/give](http://fccla.org/give). Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.*

### **Offertory**

**Art Thou Troubled?**  
Tiffany Ho, *Soprano*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ*

G. F. HANDEL

### **\*Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,  
let the Creator's praise arise!  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
till suns shall rise and set no more.  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

### **\*Offering Prayer**

**Gavin Gregorio**

Holy One, as we give our offerings  
may our eyes be open  
to see you in all the colors of creation  
as you use our generosity to awaken us  
to a new sense of awe and wonder.

May we know you, O God, as the sacred presence that is real to us.  
May we know you, O God, as the one who is the source of inspiration  
and courage as you keep calling us forward  
to share your dream for our world.

May it be so.  
*May it be so for all of us!*  
*Amen.*

*Please be seated*

**Life at First Church**

**Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin**

**Words of Blessing**

**Rev. Lehman**

May the God you see in all the colors of creation  
awaken in you a sense of awe and wonder.  
*May the God who is a sacred presence be real to you.*  
May the God who is the source of inspiration and courage  
keep calling you forward.  
*May your God go with you and bless you.*  
May it be so.  
*May it be so for all of us!*

**Choral Response**

Peace, Be Still

SHAWN KIRCHNER

*Peace, be still, and know that I am God. Peace, be still, and know that I am  
Peace, be still, and know. Peace, be still. Peace, be. Peace, peace, peace.*

**\*Hymn for the Journey**

**Wake Now My Senses**

SLANE

Wake now my senses, and hear the Earth call,  
Feel the deep power of being in all,  
Keep with the web of creation your vow,  
Giving, receiving, as love shows us how.

Wake now my reason, reach out for the new,  
Join with each trav'ler who quests for the true,  
Honor the beauty and wisdom of time,  
Transcend our limits and touch the sublime.

Wake now my vision, the dream we hold dear,  
Brighten our pathway with radiance here,  
Journey together with all who will share,  
Love for the planet transformed by our care.

--lyrics Mikelson

**Postlude**

TBD

**Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence**

### **Inside The Music**

"When I stood on the rocks of Iona, Scotland, I felt a deep and immediate connection to my ancestors and the breath and matter that formed them. Though I am not of Indigenous Celtic descent, standing on rocks over 3 billion years old that had survived erosion, climate change, billions of years of tectonic shifting, and that stood through the forcible removal and genocide of the Indigenous people on those lands reawakened and reconnected me with a fully embodied knowledge of my body and my soul. It is this *deep knowing* of which the Celts speak and it poured through my body without my even asking. Today, we begin Part II of our Fall Series, *Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul*, where we explore the Celtic

theology of Original Goodness: that at our birth we are a reflection of the Divine themselves — a mirrored image of the soul of God.

To start this journey, we sing an *Alleluia* from this island which birthed Celtic theology. A melody that seems as though it has always been flowing, inviting us to sing it during our time, and after which it will keep flowing. When I was in Iona and our guide, the Celtic theologian John Phillip Newell, taught us this melody, a wave of excitement passed through me as I realized I had known the tune my entire life. I hadn't known of its ancient Celtic origins, but somehow, it had found its way into the life of a Mediterranean girl from Boston. And isn't music like that? It can remind us of our interconnectedness and wholeness, of the goodness that is innate within us, which connects us over time and place.

Tiffany sings and Christoph plays of this connection within and throughout us in Handel's melody, *Art Thou Troubled? Music will calm thee. Art thou weary? Rest shall be thine*. And Lorenzo and the Cathedral Choir also encourage our inner lights shining through Moses Hogan's arrangement of the well-loved African-American spiritual *This Little Light of Mine*. For in the theology of the Indigenous Celts we are reminded of that inner light—present at our birth—meant to be shared as a beacon for ourselves and others. In closing, we sing the Peace Canon of Los Angeles musician and friend Shawn Kirchner, where we sing individually and collectively, *Be Still and Know that I am Peace.*" ~ Dr. Ianthe Marini

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